Between May 2004 and May 2014, Sonia Gandhi was the most powerful person in the country. Everyone within and outside the government, including the prime minister, acknowledged it. It was quite simply the nature of the ruling arrangement that had been created when Mrs Gandhi, citing her ‘inner voice’, declined to be the prime minister and chose Dr Singh instead. She was the chairperson, Dr Singh was her hand-picked Chief Executive Officer. It was an understanding based, above all else, on mutual trust and respect. It was also an agreement that suited both. Dr Singh, as the quintessential bureaucrat, was used to taking orders and handling the nitty-gritty of governance; Sonia was happy to wield power without the daily responsibilities of office.

Former Congressman Natwar Singh in his book *One Life Is*

Not Enough has claimed that Sonia’s decision not to become prime minister was dictated by Rahul, who feared for her life. ‘The inner voice theory is bunkum,’ Natwar claimed in several interviews. Was it a conscience call? I had asked Sonia Gandhi this question during a private meeting, soon after she turned down the prime ministership. She had merely nodded her head enigmatically. It is likely that the decision was taken at the family high table in the presence of Rahul, Priyanka and a few close friends, but the final call was hers. The ‘inner voice’ theory may have been a convenient political spin—it did confer on her a moral halo of martyrdom. But then again, how many politicians will give up what can be so easily theirs?

I first met Sonia Gandhi in 1995 in Amethi when she had launched a veiled attack on then prime minister Narasimha Rao, accusing the government of ‘going slow’ in the Rajiv Gandhi assassination investigation. ‘Are you joining politics?’ we had asked her excitedly then. ‘No, I am not. But I do believe that Rajivji’s sacrifice must not be forgotten,’ she had responded. The grieving widow in white seeking justice for her husband—Sonia’s political profile seemed to be an extension of her private persona as a guardian of the family legacy, keeper of the Nehru–Gandhi flame. You didn’t sense then that she was cut out for the rough and tumble of electoral politics.